Stereotypically Asian -- A Program

By Candace Chiang and Alex Dang

INTRODUCTION

Many young Asian-Americans struggle with their bi-cultural identities -- expected to adhere to multiple sets of norms, none of which quite fit. On one hand, they're encouraged to embrace American culture and shed ties to their Asian heritage. On the other hand, they're expected to maintain their ethnic identity and keep their parents' traditions alive. Failure to live up to either set of expectations can sometimes lead to a fear of rejection, being ostracized. even an identity crisis of sorts.

Just what does it mean to be . . . Stereotypically Asian – A Program with poems by Candace Chiang and Alex Dang

Stereotypically Asian by Candace Chiang

when i was 14, i

consoled a crying friend

over her math grade.

she laughed

self-deprecatingly.

"am i even asian, then?"

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when i was 15, i

helped a friend in math every day.

she wasn't doing well,

no matter how much effort she put in. one day,

frustrated, she announced her hatred for the school,

for the area and its culture,

for silicon valley.

when i was 16, i

learned that a friend was depressed,

maybe even borderline suicidal.

when i was 17, i

was talking to my friend when

she let spill that she wanted to pursue the humanities

and ranted that she was the only goddamn asian

in this school, in the bay area even,

who didn't want to pursue stem.

people call asians the "model minority."

we're associated

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with being smart
and generally overachieving, videos of amazing performers
waved off with a, “well, he’s asian,” comment that
apparently
explains everything.
we’re all upper-middle class who make
lots of money in big corporations.
we all score incredibly on tests,
go to top-100 colleges and successful careers.
we’re heterosexual, complacent and apolitical.
we have small eyes, faces that white men
sometimes find attractive.
we’re east asian,
chinese, japanese, korean.
we’re the “model minority.”

and so asians are lumped into one huge category,
and stereotyped.
but many of us are dirt poor.
but asians are ethnically more diverse than
chinese, japanese, korean
(even if some are now classified as

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pacific islanders, because they’re different
from the image people associate “asian” with).
but hand in hand with this stereotype is
a culture of ever-increasing stress, pressure, overwork,
and an intense fear of failure —
a culture people are failing to address.
but we aren’t represented in government.
but when you’re asian and applying for
colleges, jobs, positions,
you’re forced to find ways to “stand out”
and prove yourself to be different
from the stereotype, because apparently,
no one wants that.

in many cases, i’m probably a stellar example
of the “model minority.”
i’m at a top college. i did well in school.
i’m even pursuing computer science, and so supposedly,
i will land a six-figure job right out of college.
but that barely tells you anything about me,
about my experiences,
about my interests,

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and if i am going to be judged and

have my voice dismissed because i fit the “asian”

stereotype,

i will tear apart these notions of me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Candace Chiang
Newspaper: The Daily Californian
Website:
https://www.dailycal.org/stereotypically-asian-poem
Publisher: Dailycal.org
Date (Month/Year): November 5, 2017

What Kind of Asian are You? by Alex Dang

So she said to me: "What kind of Asian are you?" And I

said back . . .

“That's a loaded question.

What kind of Asian do you EXPECT me to be?

Because any way you slice that egg roll,

I'm still pretty much whatever you want to see.”

I've played many a Far East stereotype:

awkward math genius,

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cold and calculated Kung-Fu expert,

assistant to "Dr. Jones, you crazy!"

You want me to drive? How so?

I can give you

Tokyo Drift,

Jeremy Lin

Mario Kart,

Tiger Woods,

and Blinker left on for about half a mile

I am the foremost expert on

all things Asian.

The Mejii era and the ban of the Samurai?

Done.

Confuciusism versus Daoism? I'll give it to you with no

slant!

What's the difference between Asian stereotype

1 and 2?

WELL LET ME TELL YOU.

Let me tell you anything YOU

want to know about my culture

Let me tell you in a Mulan-esque soliloquy

of me staring in the mirror asking
Who IS that girl staring that I see?
Let me tell you about Jackie Chan
and Bruce Lee and how they are related
BY BLOOD to me
Let me tell you about being so marginalized
it's to the point of "I really CAN'T believe
that's Asian!"
Let me tell you about derogatory terms
and origins of words such as chink and gook
Let me tell you about the struggle
of Asian parents not knowing the language
so we ate pet food because it was cheaper
Let me tell you about the job of interpreter
when you're still playing with LEGO blocks but
you're English is already that much better
than your guardians
Let me tell you about honor and dignity
Let me tell you about a society that
projects us as nothing but the secondary role
and never the leading man.

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Let me tell you all the things you don't want
to know.
Like how chink comes from
the clanking of metal to railroads
as the slaves built train tracks for
this country to be connected.
Like how the zipperhead down the street
is called that because of the way our heads
split open when struck with assault weapons
or how the Jeeps ran over and left marks
across corpses and someone clever thought
that we were only good to unzip.
Like how every time you lump an Asian person
into one culture is systematically making us
assimilate into an America we thought was
better than our war torn home and every time you
confuse me
with some other nationality that I might share similar
features to is stripping away my individuality
And I still feel the shame of being Asian
the heat and pious dedication

of June 11th 1963

the envy of blonde hair

and blue eyes

And I still remember thinking where all the

boys that looked like me on TV were

the broken words

of my mother and father stage diving

off my tongue

the anger I felt when those

kids thought I'd get them sick

And I still feel the ash of the incense burn

my hands

when I prayed for my family

And I still remember thinking my skin

was what I was worth

And I still feel the ironwork of my bones

grow stronger with every train of thought

that

passes by

And I still feel pride

And I still feel heritage

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And I still feel Chinese

And I still feel Vietnamese

And I still feel American

And I still feel

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Alex Dang
Book: You Can Do Better
ASIN: B00YSYVI5A
Publisher: Where Are You Press
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2014

Transcript of poem also available on-line at https://www.poemhunter.com/poem/what-kind-of-asian-are-you/

Performance at the National 2013 Poetry Slam can be viewed here:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VoP0ox_Jw_w&t=8s

AWARD HISTORY

2021 National Qualifier – MS (as a collection)
KS State Qualifier (What Kind of Asian Are You?)

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